

Looking for ideas

The first stage in practical innovation is gathering ideas for new projects. Innovation can be triggered by many different pressures, and to manage it effectively you must have mechanisms to pick up on these pressures. These can come from within your organization, or from the wider world.

HOW TO... SEARCH FOR IDEAS

Explore existing technology to find opportunity.

Research the potential market for your product.

Investigate your competition and learn from them.

Look at threats and opportunities for your business.

Use stakeholders' ideas for new perspectives.

Pushing the frontiers

New developments in science have always pushed the frontiers of knowledge and created opportunities for innovation. Use the Internet or "knowledge brokers" to help cast the search net widely. With nearly \$1 trillion being spent every year on R&D around the world, the problem is less one of knowledge creation than one of tapping into existing research. Conduct your own technological research—creating new knowledge—or tap into research being done elsewhere, such as at universities or research institutes. Working with other organizations will help you share the costs and risks.

Meeting demand

Necessity is the mother of invention, so making sure you understand user needs will help you pick up clear signals for innovation. Getting close to actual or potential customers and understanding their needs will help you understand user needs. Market research is one good source of this, as are customer service and complaint records. Needs are not just about external markets for products and services—demand pull works inside the organization as well, as a driver of process innovation. Pay attention to sources of frustration highlighted by your workforce, and plan innovation to ease them.